Oil Markets Weekly

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Red Sea and Hormuz conflicts combine to keep prices high

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While the US backed away from escalation for the second weekend in a row, the continued risk of more intense violence will keep prices in a $75-$95 per barrel band for Brent.
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The disruption of Red Sea traffic adds additional pressure to prices, though alternative routes are limiting the impact.
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Iran will demand an end to the US blockade—which has once again driven Iranian oil exports to zero—as a condition in any agreement to reopen the strait.

Prices will stay in $75-$95 per barrel range but would go still higher if the US escalates. US President Donald Trump opted against escalation for the second weekend in a row, causing prices to once again oscillate: The Brent per barrel front month rose to $90 on Friday only to fall sharply to $83 by Monday morning.

Along with the ever-shifting escalation risk, the limited flow of oil leaving the Gulf and China's continued reluctance to resume full-scale oil imports are helping to keep markets stable in the short term. Absent US escalation against Iran or a significant intensification of hostilities in the Red Sea, prices are likely to trade in a $75-95 per barrel range for Brent; should the US escalate, as remains likely before mid-September, prices will rise into a $90-$110 range.

Red Sea and Hormuz conflicts combine to keep prices high. While the ongoing US-Iran conflict is keeping the Strait of Hormuz largely closed to traffic, the conflict between Saudi Arabia and the Houthis in Yemen will disrupt but not completely halt Saudi exports from the Red Sea port of Yanbu (which average 4 million-4.5 million barrels per day). Saudi tankers are largely avoiding the Bab el-Mandeb following a string of Houthi attacks. However, capacity in the Suez Canal and the Sumed pipeline are allowing Saudi exports to continue, though via the longer and more circuitous route around Africa.

Depressed Chinese imports will continue to put downward pressure on prices. Though they recovered following the US-Iran deal in late June, Chinese oil imports are slumping once again and are unlikely to exceed 8 million bpd in August based on estimated deliveries.

Iran won't reopen the strait unless the US ends its blockade. The return of the US blockade has caused Iran's oil exports to decline once again, with weekly loadings falling to zero in August. While Iran is in discussions with Oman regarding a new arrangement in the Strait of Hormuz, it is unlikely to relax its posture in the strait and end its attacks on tankers until the US agrees to end the blockade, allowing it to resume exports.

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